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TikTok adds new parental controls, tools for creators

TikTok announced on Wednesday that it's releasing a slew of new features, including enhanced parental controls, additional tools for creators, and a new interactive well-being feature. It also [publicly launched Footnotes](#), its fact-checking system.

The social network is bringing new parental controls to Family Pairing, its feature that allows parents to link their accounts with their teen's account to customize safety settings. Parents can now block specific accounts for their teen's account. Blocked accounts can't interact with the teen, and the teen won't see the account's content in their feed.

IMAGE CREDITS:

JAKUB PORZYCKI / NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

Parents will also now automatically be notified when their teen uploads a public video, story, or photo. TikTok says this will help parents stay informed about what their teen is posting without disrupting their creativity.

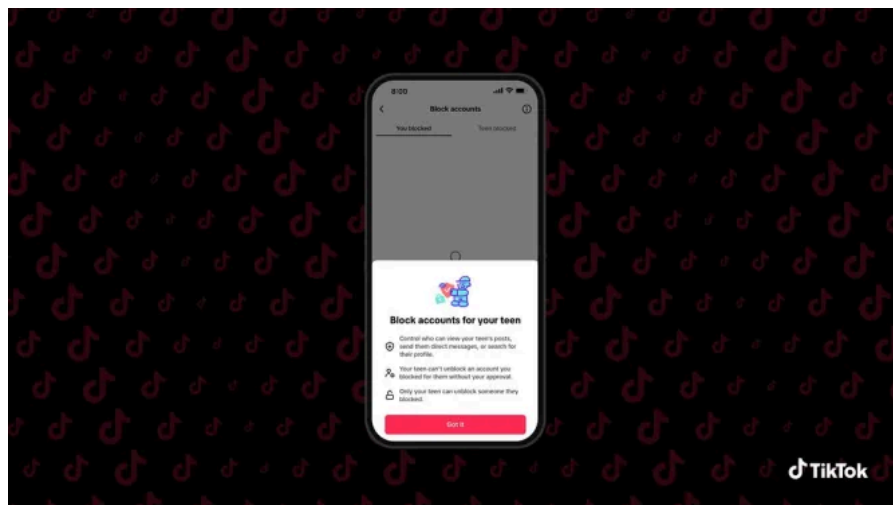


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

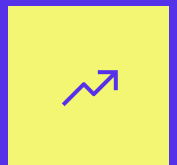
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Parents now get more visibility into the privacy settings that their teen selects. For example, they can see if their teen (aged 16 to 17) has enabled downloads for their content or if their following list is visible to others.

TikTok is also launching “Creator Care Mode,” which automatically filters all comments identified as offensive, inappropriate, or profane. It also filters comments from users whose comments are reported, disliked, or deleted.

TikTok says the feature uses AI to understand how the user is blocking and deleting the content. So, if a creator repeatedly deletes or reports certain types of comments, then those kinds of comments are less likely to appear in their comment section.

A new comment tool for TikTok Live will allow creators to block a word from their comments entirely. Plus, users who previously commented the phrase or who comment the phrase in the future will be muted for the creator’s chosen duration.

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TikTok

IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

To help creators better manage messages, TikTok is launching a new professional inbox experience called the “Creator Inbox,” which includes “Unread” and “Starred” folders. Creators can also set up custom responses to address commonly asked questions, and they can create quick replies for sharing these responses with one tap.

TikTok is also launching Creator Chat Room, which allows creators to connect and interact directly with eligible followers on TikTok. Creators and their followers can message back and forth with each other in the Chat Room.

Creator Chat Rooms are available to creators who are at least 18 years old, have at least 10,000 followers, and have either a Subscription or Live Fan Club. Chats are capped at 300 people, and creators can have at least 20 different chats.

Creators will also get access to “Content Check Lite,” which is a new feature that allows users to check if their content is eligible to appear in the For You feed. This way, users can make any necessary changes before posting.

TikTok is also testing a broader Content Check functionality that will allow creators to check if their content adheres to the social network’s Community Guidelines before it goes live on platform.

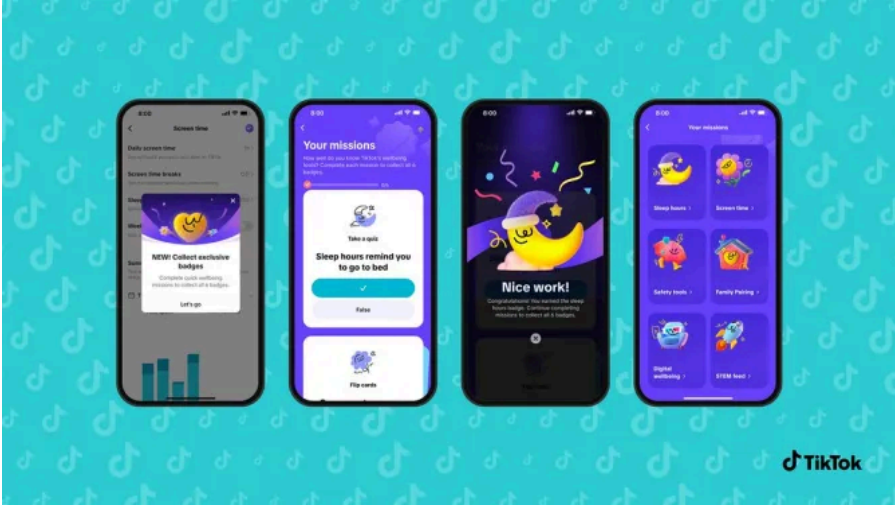


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The social network also announced that it’s launching a new feature called “Well-being Missions,” which are series of short quizzes and interactive flash cards to help people develop balanced digital habits. Users earn badges as they complete these missions.

TikTok says it’s building a new in-app dedicated digital well-being experience that will feature tools like breathing exercises, calming audio tracks, and screen time insights to help people recharge.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#) [🦋](#) [in](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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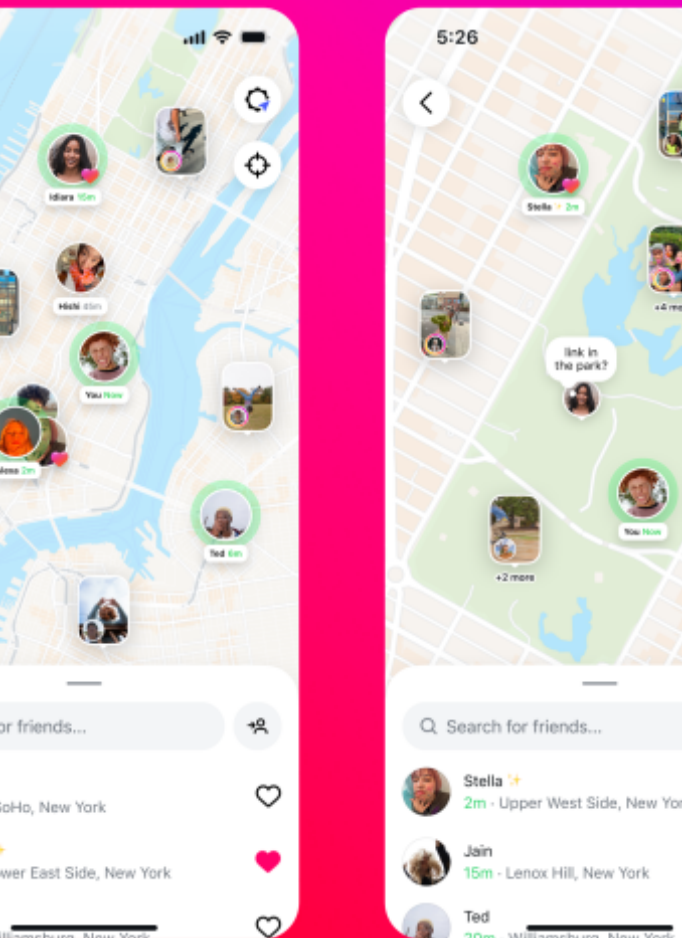


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik — 7:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Instagram is rolling out Instagram Map, a new feature that lets users share their most recent active location with others and discover location-based content. The Meta-owned social network is also launching reposts, and making its “Friends” tab in Reels available globally.

With its new map feature, Instagram is copying yet another popular feature from Snapchat, after cloning the app’s core Stories functionality [back in 2016](#). Instagram is coming for Snap Map’s crown, a feature that recently surpassed 400 million monthly active users and remains one of the app’s core offerings.

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Instagram notes that location sharing is off by default on Instagram Map, and a user's location only updates when they open the app, meaning it doesn't provide real-time location updates. Snap Map, on the other hand, allows users to choose whether their location is updated only when they open the app or in real time.

It's worth noting that Instagram does offer [real-time location sharing via DMs](#) (direct messages). However, unlike Apple's Find My and Snap Map, which let you share your location with others indefinitely, Instagram only lets users do so for up to one hour.

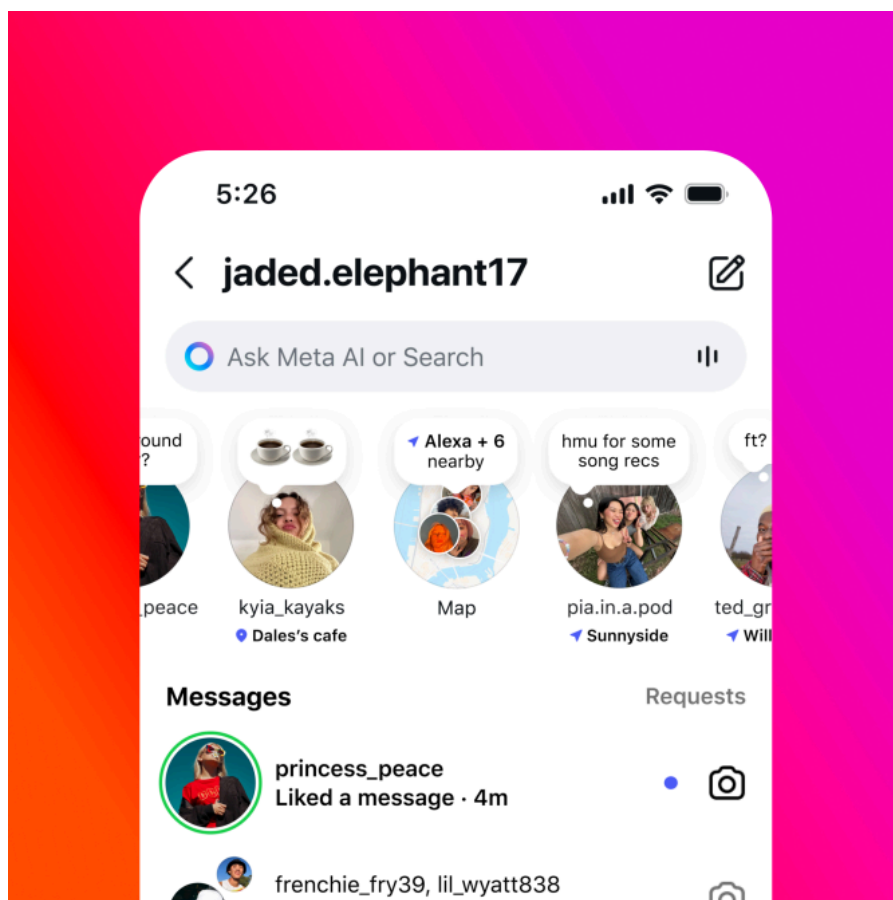


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

Instagram says the new map feature will make it easier for friends to coordinate and link up for hangouts. It also lets users explore location-based content that their friends and favorite creators have shared or engaged with. For example, if your friend attends a nearby music festival and posts a story while there, it will appear on the map. Similarly, if a

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creator posts a reel about a new restaurant in your city, you'll be able to discover it on Instagram Map.

Regardless of whether you choose to share your location, you can use the map to explore location-based content, Instagram says.

The map also allows users to leave short messages, or "[Notes](#)," on the map for others to see. Instagram Notes are currently the short messages that appear at the top of your direct messaging feed, but with the launch of Instagram Map, users can now post these short updates on the map.

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Although Instagram is certainly taking on Snapchat with this new feature, it also has the opportunity to appeal to people who were fans of [Zenly](#), a social map app that Snap acquired and then shut down in 2023.

The new map feature is launching in the United States starting Wednesday, with broader global

availability coming soon. Users can find the Instagram Map at the top of their DM inbox.

The launch doesn't come as a surprise, as [Instagram was spotted developing](#) the map feature last year.

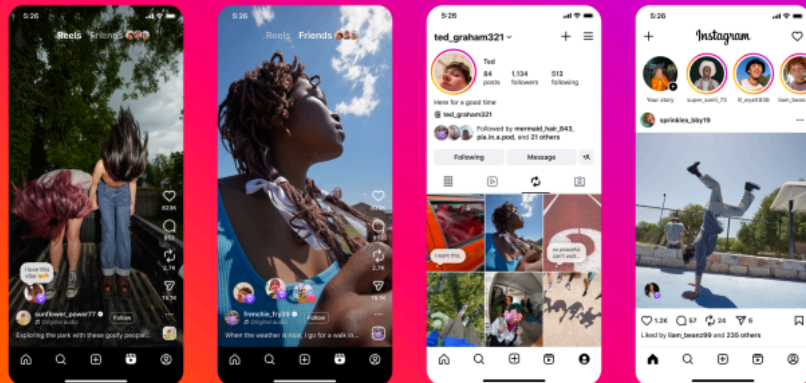


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

As for the new “Reposts” feature, Instagram is taking a page out of [TikTok’s book](#) while also creating its own version of the popular “retweet” function from Twitter (now X).

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This feature lets Instagram users repost public reels and feed posts. These reposts may show up in their friends' feeds and will also be displayed in a new “Reposts” tab on their profile. Instagram says the new feature gives users a way to share their interests with others and also offers creators the opportunity to reach a wider audience.

To repost a reel or post, users tap the repost icon. Users can also choose to add a note to the repost by typing into the thought bubble that appears on screen and pressing save.

Regarding the new “Friends” tab in Reels, Instagram launched it in the United States earlier this year and is now making it available globally. The tab lets you see public reels that your friends have liked, commented on, reposted, and created.

For users who want to browse and interact with content privately, Instagram is rolling out the ability to opt out of having content you’ve engaged with shown in the friends tab.

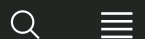
Users can hide their likes, comments, and reposts from the tab. Additionally, they can choose to mute likes, comments, and reposts from specific people they follow.

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The backlash against Duolingo going 'AI-first' didn't even matter

Amanda Silberling — 8:32 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

Duolingo [announced](#) on Wednesday that it beat its quarterly revenue estimates, even though the company faced widespread backlash for choosing to embrace generative AI over human workers. Duolingo stock rose [almost 30%](#) on the news.

IMAGE CREDITS: DUOLINGO

In April, CEO Luis von Ahn [shared](#) that Duolingo would become an “AI-first” company, phasing out its use of contract workers. He also discouraged teams from hiring more employees, unless the team is unable to automate more of its work. With the use of generative AI, Duolingo introduced 148 new language courses, more than doubling its previous offerings.

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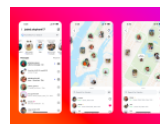
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“Without AI, it would take us decades to scale our content to more learners,” von Ahn wrote at the

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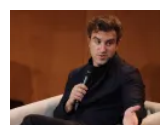
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Sarah Perez - 13 hours ago

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The backlash against Duolingo going 'AI-first' didn't even matter

Amanda Silberling
- 13 hours ago

time. “We owe it to our learners to get them this content ASAP.”

While some Duolingo users have argued that these AI features are making the app worse, the company’s financial metrics tell a different story. Now the company [anticipates](#) making over \$1 billion in revenue this year, and daily active users have grown 40% year-over-year. The growth is significant but falls in the lower range of the company’s estimates of growing between 40% and 45%, which an investor brought up to von Ahn on Wednesday’s quarterly earnings call.

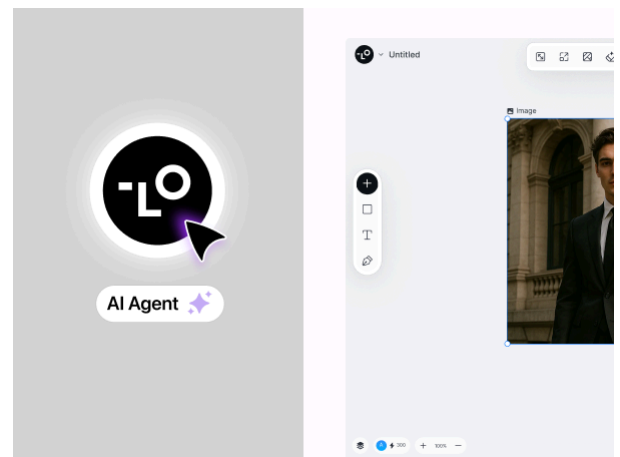
“The reason we came [in] towards the lower end was because I said some stuff about AI, and I didn’t give enough context. Because of that, we got some backlash on social media,” von Ahn said. “The most important thing is we wanted to make the sentiment on our social media positive. We stopped posting edgy posts and started posting things that would get our sentiment more positive. That has worked.”

On TikTok, the top comments on Duolingo’s videos often remain criticisms of the company’s AI approach. Snarky commenters will ask if videos with multiple people in them are made with AI, to which Duolingo will reply, “Nope. Made by our great team!”

But even if public sentiment toward Duolingo has shifted, its bottom line has not ... and from the company’s perspective, that’s what matters.

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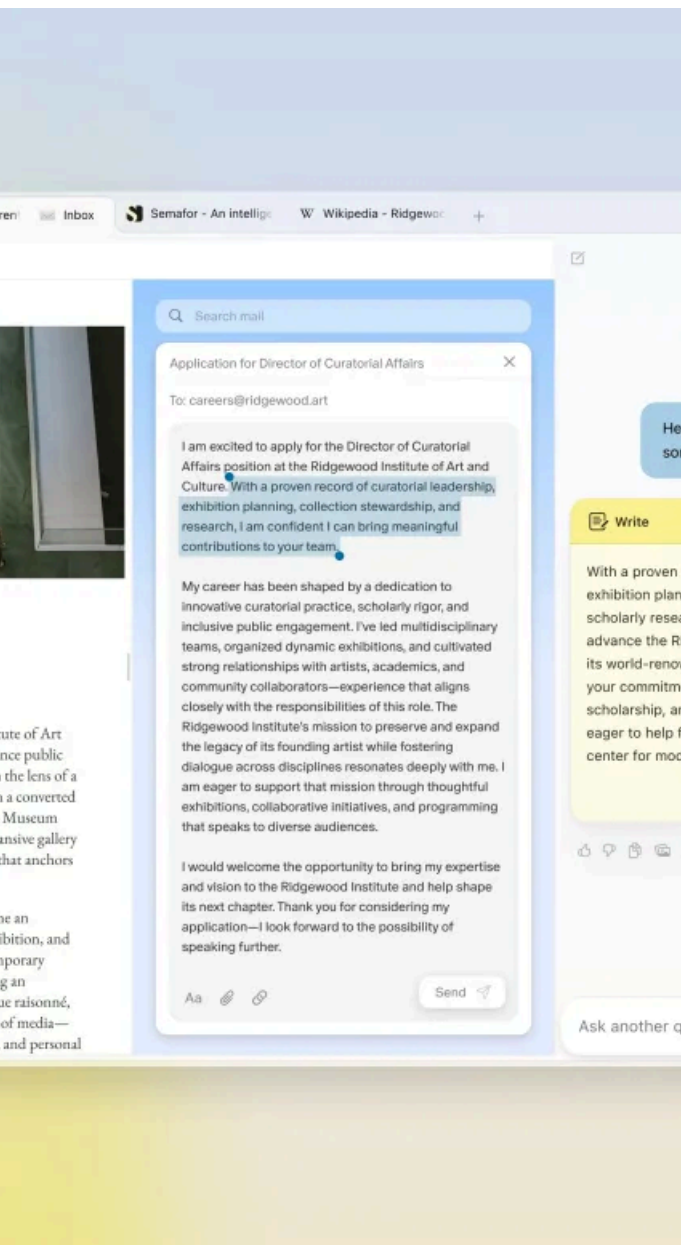


IMAGE CREDITS: THE BROWSER COMPANY

APPS



The Browser Company launches a \$20 monthly subscription for its AI-powered browser

Ivan Mehta — 11:26 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

The [Browser Company](#) has launched a Pro subscription plan for Dia, its new web browser that heavily integrates AI features. The plan costs \$20

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per month and provides unlimited access to Dia’s AI-powered chat and skills features.

The introduction of a paid tier means free users will now face usage limits on AI features. While The Browser Company hasn’t specified exact limits, CEO Josh Miller told [The New York Times](#) in July that the browser will remain free for those who use AI features “a few times a week.”

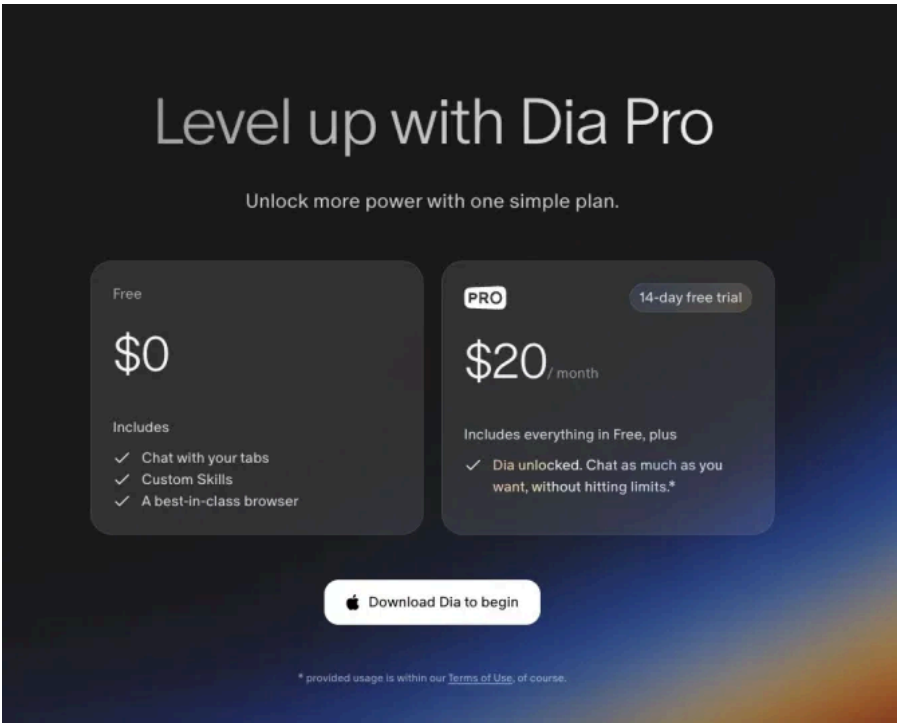


IMAGE CREDITS:SCREENSHOT BY TECHCRUNCH

Miller also indicated that the startup plans to offer multiple subscription tiers, ranging from \$5 per month to hundreds of dollars monthly. The current \$20 plan appears to be one of several options based on different feature sets.

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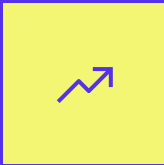
Just launched: Lovart, the AI design agent building entire campaigns in 3 minutes
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Earlier this week, users on [Reddit](#) and [Threads](#) noticed that The Browser Company had quietly made the Pro plan available online. However, the company quickly removed the page. Now the

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subscription option has been restored and can be accessed through Dia's settings page.

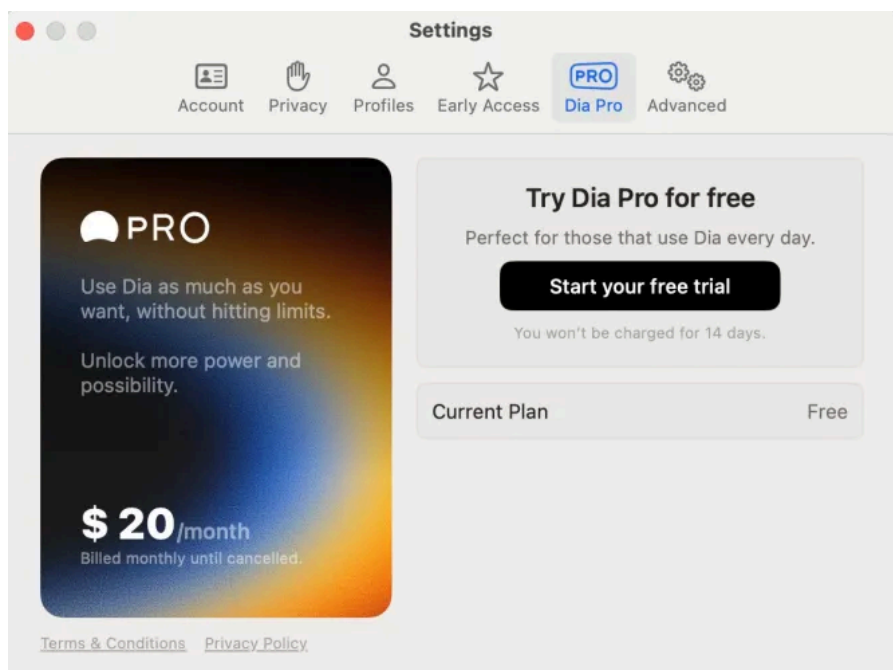
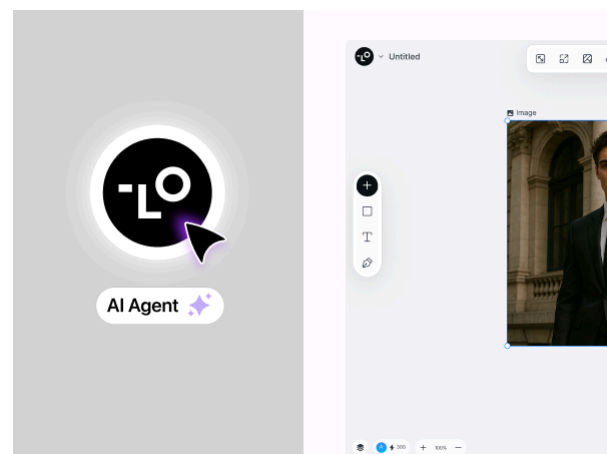


IMAGE CREDITS: SCREENSHOT BY TECHCRUNCH

The Browser Company, which previously made [the Arc browser](#), has raised [\\$128 million](#) from investors, including Pace Capital, Next Play Ventures, and notable tech execs like LinkedIn's Jeff Weiner, Medium's Ev Williams, Figma's Dylan Field, Notion's Akshay Kothari, and GitHub's Jason Warner. This Pro plan represents the company's first revenue-generating subscription service.

The startup faces growing competition when it comes to AI-enhanced browsers. Perplexity's [Comet browser](#) is gaining steam, Opera is also prepping its [Neon browser](#), and incumbents like [Google](#) and [Microsoft](#) are also integrating their AI assistants into their browsers.

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